Design Justification Report

This document outlines the design philosophy, visual aesthetics, and user experience (UX) rationale behind **played**, a social game logging application. Inspired by platforms like Letterboxd, the app is designed to provide gamers with an immersive, highly accessible, and visually appealing environment to track, review, and discover video games.

1. Color Palette & Visual Identity

The application employs a deliberate "Dark Mode by Default" aesthetic. This choice is highly intentional for our target demographic (gamers), as it reduces eye strain during prolonged screen time, feels native to gaming ecosystems, and allows vivid game poster artwork to stand out without competing with bright backgrounds.

Background	Icons / Accents	Primary Text	Secondary Text
#2c0016	#4f4e80	#e4cbbf	#938282

- **Background (#2c0016):** A deep, rich burgundy/plum tone. Instead of a harsh pure black (#000000), this color provides a cinematic and premium feel, creating depth while maintaining excellent contrast ratios.
- **Icons & Interactive Elements (#4f4e80):** A muted indigo. It acts as a distinct accent color for our HUD and interactive elements, providing clear visual cues for clickable areas without overwhelming the screen.
- **Typography - Primary (#e4cbbf) & Secondary (#938282):** Using a soft peach/beige for main text rather than pure white minimizes harsh glare against the dark background, improving readability (accessibility). The muted greyish-pink establishes a clear visual hierarchy for subtitles, release years, and less critical data.

2. Typography Choices

Establishing a strong, readable, and recognizable typographic hierarchy is crucial for a data-heavy application like **played**.

- **Main UI Font (Poppins):** Used universally across all screens for body text, headings, buttons, and inputs. Poppins is a geometric sans-serif typeface that is highly legible on mobile screens. Its rounded, friendly letterforms soften the dark UI and make reading long user reviews effortless.
- **Logo Font (Paytone One):** Used exclusively for the app's logotype. Written entirely in lowercase (**played**), it provides a heavy, casual, and distinctive brand identity that instantly catches the eye on the Welcome and Home screens.

3. Layout & Accessibility (UX)

The layout is architected around **thumb-zone accessibility** and **progressive disclosure**, ensuring users are never overwhelmed by information.

Navigation & HUD

A persistent bottom navigation bar (HUD) anchors the user experience. Containing *Home*, *Search*, and *Profile* icons, it adheres to Fitts's Law by keeping primary navigation easily reachable at the bottom of the screen. Accessibility is reinforced through visual feedback: the active page's icon is highlighted in a lighter shade to ensure users always know their current location in the app.

Onboarding Flow

The initial user journey emphasizes low friction. The sequence transitions smoothly from the **Welcome Screen** (brand reinforcement via the logo and a short delay) to the **Login Screen**. For new users, the **Sign Up Screen** requests only essential information (Username, Email, Password, Confirm Password, and Terms & Conditions). This streamlined approach prevents user drop-off during the critical early adoption phase.

4. Screen Specific Design Logic

The visual arrangement of data within core screens is structured to highlight community and content, keeping the focus entirely on the games.

Screen	Design & Layout Justification
Home & Feed	Features horizontal scrolling carousels for *Trending Games* and *Reviews from Friends*. This UI pattern maximizes vertical screen real estate, allowing users to browse multiple categories simultaneously without endless vertical scrolling.

Screen	Design & Layout Justification
Game Detail	Prioritizes visual impact. The game poster, release year, platform, and average rating dominate the top section. The official synopsis provides context, followed directly by the primary Call-to-Action (CTA): the **Log** button. Below this, vertical scrolling is utilized for user reviews, keeping the layout clean while accommodating long-form text.
Log Screen	Designed for rapid data entry. It echoes the game's metadata (poster, year) at the top for confirmation. Quick-action toggle buttons (*Play*, *Like*, *Wishlist*) and a standard 5-star rating system precede the text area for the review. This reduces the cognitive load required to log a game.
Profile & Games	Acts as a personal showcase. The top header displays vital stats (Games Played, Review Count). The layout utilizes horizontal scrolling for the user's top 5 *Favorite Games* and 8 *Played Recently* games to create a highly visual, poster-driven grid. Categorized tabs (*Played, Wishlist, Likes*) and dedicated social pages (*Followers, Following, Reviews*) ensure complex user data is neatly compartmentalized.
Search	Features an immediate top-anchored search bar and a *Recently Searched* history list below. This minimizes repetitive typing and speeds up the discovery process, which is essential for a cataloging application.

5. Conclusion

The design choices for **played-**from the atmospheric #2c0016 color palette to the Poppins typography and thumb-friendly HUD-work in concert to deliver a premium user experience. By heavily relying on horizontal carousels, clear visual hierarchies, and starkly contrasting text, the interface remains uncluttered and accessible, fully supporting the goal of creating an engaging social logging platform for gamers.